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The Jewels in my Crown

On 4 May 1963, a day before my wedding, my baraat left Chandigarh for Pathankot. By now Isher and the rest of my family had accepted the fact that Nimmi and I were going to be married. They arrived for my seharbandi ceremony and took charge of all the rites and rituals. I happily submitted, not having the heart to dampen their enthusiasm. Isher, despite her earlier objections, was elated that her brother had, at last, decided to settle down with the girl of his dreams.

There was almost two hundred of us in my baraat— relatives, colleagues and close friends, among them Kartar Singh and Sardar Umrao Singh, sports minister and president of the Indian Athletics' Association, whom we picked up from Jalandhar.

Thousands of people had congregated on the streets and on the roofs of houses to welcome our cavalcade as we wended our way through the streets and bazaars of Pathankot, cheering and showering us with rose petals. There were loud cries of 'Milkha Singh, Milkha Singh!' When we entered the bride's home, Makhan Singh did the honours, embracing and exchanging garlands with Nimmi's brother, Dev Dutt. Then it was time for the bride's appearance. Supported by her sisters and friends, she slowly came towards me, her head demurely covered by a voluminous dupatta. We garlanded each other. After the jaimala, the reception of the baraat was held, and then my family, friends and I returned to the guesthouse where we were staying.

The next morning, we arrived at the bride's house for the Anand Karaj. Nimmi looked beautiful, all dressed in her wedding finery—a heavy red